

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a family magazine article about parenting:

How children succeed

How Children Succeed by Paul Tough (HMH, 2012) takes the reader through a series of real life examples of children, educators and psychologists who have turned out talented, intelligent and balanced people.

One of the most common aspects of the traditional Hong Kong education is that children need to be pushed as hard as possible. Tough, in the book, supports this theory with stories of how 13-year-olds from low-income families can become chess masters through putting in hours and hours of practice. It is similar to the idea that Malcolm Gladwell raised in his book, *Outliers*. He says we need 10,000 hours of 'deliberate practice' to master a skill.

In the book, Tough cites several studies that prove external incentives (rewards given by someone other than yourself) don't work in the long term. If you offer money for blood donations, over time fewer donors show up. If you offer cell-phone credits to students, their grades do not increase. Tough asserts that the motivation must come from within ourselves. Children need to want to succeed, to do well on the test, to understand what achieving something will bring them.

While nowadays it may seem too cold and discouraging to have no sticker charts, house points or gold stars in school, it may be that we need to push our children to find their own internal incentives.

Your group has to make a presentation to a group of parents about helping children to succeed. Discuss with your group what to include in the presentation. You may want to talk about:

- ways that Hong Kong parents try to help their children to succeed
- what motivates Hong Kong children to succeed
- advice to give parents
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Did you enjoy your primary school life?
2. Do you think students should have more free time?
3. Do you think children in Hong Kong live a balanced life?
4. What motivates you to succeed?
5. Do you agree that children need to be pushed as hard as possible?
6. Do external incentives such as money or gifts motivate you to succeed?
7. Do you think parents in Hong Kong place too much emphasis on external success?
8. What is your idea of success?